

Bushey Swimming Club History Report

Executive summary

The open-access evidence supports the user's belief that **Bushey Amateur Swimming Club was founded in 1926**, but it does **not** yet support an exact founding day or a fully documented founding meeting. The two strongest open-access club/club-linked confirmations are the club's own welcome pack, which states that it was "Established in 1926", and the club's centenary/anniversary trail: the 2015 AGM minutes treated **2016 as the 90th anniversary**, and the live centenary page treats **2026 as the 100th birthday**. A 2016 local news feature adds an important contextual claim: the club was "founded in King George V pool in 1926". ¹

The wider local-history record helps explain those circumstances. Official Hertsmere/ParksHerts history for King George Recreation Ground states that the **open-air swimming pool at the Rec was built and ceremonially opened in July 1925**, after the Recreation Ground had been enlarged in the early 1920s. On the present evidence, the most plausible reconstruction is therefore: **the pool opened in 1925, and the club was organised in or around the first full season after that opening, in 1926**. That is a strong inference, but the open web still lacks the founding minute-book, the first membership list, or the contemporary 1926 newspaper report that would turn the inference into a fully primary citation. ²

After those beginnings, the evidence shows a pattern common to many English local clubs: continuity through changing facilities rather than a single continuous venue. The King George open-air pool remained a major summer civic venue through the inter-war and post-war decades, gained filtration/purification improvements in the 1950s, experienced peak popularity in the hot summer of 1976, and then closed in 1989 before demolition in 1993. By the 2000s Bushey ASC was clearly operating from indoor and school pools, including Bushey Grove Leisure Centre and John Owen Sports Centre/Merry Hill Road; by 2026 its primary base was Bushey Grove, with additional training at St Margaret's, Merchant Taylors, St Helens and Luton Sports Village. ³

The club's modern profile is that of a **small, volunteer-led competitive development club**. Current and recent official/club-linked sources show a committee-based governance structure, strong reliance on volunteers, current recruitment for children aged 5+ who are already swimming independently at about Stage 5 of the Learn to Swim pathway, participation in county swimming leagues and local galas, and a present membership figure of **214** on Swim England Poolfinder. Historical snapshots suggest that membership was **over 160** in the welcome-pack era and that, in 2016, the club publicly described its members as ranging from **age six to 54**, reflecting a broader age profile at that time than the current junior-facing public offer. ⁴

The biggest evidential gaps are: the exact founding date; the names of the founders; wartime club activity during 1939–45; a precise post-1989 relocation chronology; long-run membership statistics; and a robust list of historically notable athletes/coaches with verifiable biographies. Those gaps are likely fillable through **Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies, local newspapers, Bushey Museum, club AGM packs/minutes, trophy records, photos and surviving committee papers**. ⁵

Founding date and founding circumstances

The founding year is well corroborated. The club's own welcome pack says: **"Established in 1926"**. The 2015 AGM minutes record the club leadership explicitly saying that **2016 would be the club's 90th anniversary**, and the current centenary page labels **2026** as the club's "100th birthday". Read together, those internal markers converge on the same founding year: **1926**. ⁶

The most specific statement about circumstances comes from a 2016 local news article marking the 90th anniversary, which said that **"Bushey Swimming Club was founded in King George V pool in 1926"**. That statement is not, by itself, as strong as a founding minute or a contemporary 1926 press report, but it is consistent with the club's own anniversary chronology. ⁷

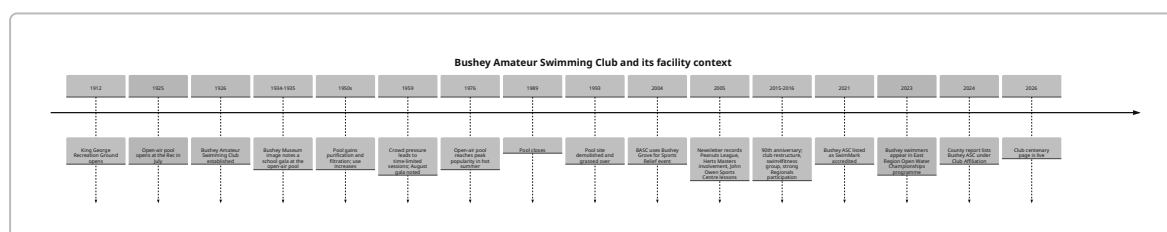
The local civic setting is more firmly documented. Official King George Recreation Ground history states that, after enlargement of the Rec in the early 1920s, **plans for an open-air swimming pool were discussed and tenders invited**, and that the pool **opened amid civic ceremony in July 1925**. This is important because it places the putative 1926 club formation immediately after the creation of a new municipal swimming facility. The likely founding circumstance was therefore not an abstract “club first, pool later” story, but a more concrete local response to a new public amenity: a recently opened outdoor pool, growing recreational provision, and the emergence of organised swimming activity around it. ²

What cannot yet be said with confidence is **who** founded the club, **on what exact date**, and **under what initial constitution or subscription structure**. No open-access source found in this research provided the original minute book, inauguration notice, or first registration with the Amateur Swimming Association. That means the founding **year** is verified, the founding **setting** is plausible and strongly supported, but the founding **meeting** remains unverified online. ⁸

A formal **name change** is also unverified. The present official name is **Bushey Amateur Swimming Club**, while shorthand forms such as **"Bushey Swimming Club"** appear in local media and social posts. On current evidence, that looks more like informal abbreviation than a demonstrated legal or constitutional renaming. ⁹

Major chronology and analytical timeline

The dated milestones below synthesise the strongest evidence located in club, council, county and museum sources. The chronology is secure for the pool/facility history and for the club's modern era, but patchier for the mid-century club itself. ¹⁰



Several moments in this timeline deserve comment. First, the **facility history matters enormously** to the club's history. King George Recreation Ground's official history records that the open-air pool became part of a broader inter-war expansion of public recreation, with tennis courts, a putting green

and other play equipment. That makes the club's apparent 1926 birth look like part of a wider local civic recreation movement rather than a standalone sporting initiative. ²

Secondly, the **inter-war and post-war pool** appears to have been a serious local venue even when the club record is thin. Bushey Museum materials refer to a **Watford Girls' Grammar School gala at the Bushey open-air pool in 1934 or 1935**, suggesting that the venue already hosted organised aquatic events. Council history then shows that, by the **1950s**, purification and filtration had materially increased use, and that by the hot summer of **1959** time-limited sessions were needed to cope with crowds; the pool also hosted a popular **end-of-season swimming gala each August**. While those sources document the facility more clearly than the club, they show the sporting environment within which BASC would have operated. ¹¹

Thirdly, the **closure of the lido/open-air pool** is the central break in the club's long physical geography. Hertsmere/ParksHerts date the pool's closure to **1989** and the demolition/levelling of the site to **1993**. That almost certainly forced BASC to become a multi-site indoor/school-pool club. By **2004**, the club newsletter records Bushey Grove Leisure Centre providing swimming facilities for a Sports Relief event; by **2005**, another newsletter advertised swimming lessons at **John Owen Sports Centre, Merry Hill Road**; by **2026**, the official Poolfinder record lists Bushey Grove as base and multiple additional training venues. The exact step-by-step migration from King George to these later pools is not yet fully documented online, but the broad transition is clear. ³

Fourthly, the **modern competitive era** is noticeably better documented. The 2015 AGM minutes describe that year as especially successful, with "the most club records beaten ever" and "the most number of swimmers competing at Regionals", alongside structural changes including revised squad allocation, licensed time trials and the launch of a **swim4fitness** group. Swim England's licensed-meets calendar later records Bushey club championships/time trials in **2021, 2022 and 2026**, which shows continuity of internal competitive organisation. ¹²

As for **notable coaches and athletes**, the open web provides only partial identification. The 2015 AGM minutes name **Jack Jackson** as the figure presenting the club's next five-year swimming plan and squad restructure, implying a leading coaching/technical role at that point. The 2016 anniversary article claims that, in recent years, Bushey swimmers had reached the **Commonwealth Games**, an **Olympic Team GB trial**, and **European Masters** competition, but it does not identify those swimmers by name. Official recent external programmes do name contemporary Bushey swimmers: the East Region Open Water Championships programme for 2023 lists **Barnaby O'Donnell** and **Katy Ord** among Bushey entrants, giving at least a verifiable snapshot of recent representative athletes. On the governance side, named senior figures include club presidents **Wendy Cook** in the mid-2010s and **Howard Willis** in 2025. ¹³

The weakest part of the chronology is **wartime club activity**. Official Recreation Ground history records that, during the First World War, sports pitches were converted to allotments by **1916**. Bushey Museum journals also preserve local reminiscence of wartime Bushey, but the open-access materials located here did not provide a direct, club-specific BASC wartime narrative for either 1914–18 or 1939–45. At present, the safest conclusion is that wartime activity is **not verified online** and needs archive work. ¹⁴

Membership, demographics, governance and affiliation

The best current public membership figure is the Swim England Poolfinder entry, which lists **214 members** and classifies the club's abilities as **Newcomer, Improver and Competitor**. The club's older welcome pack gives a lower snapshot of "**over 160 swimming members**", which suggests growth over

time, though the two figures are not directly comparable because they may have been captured under different definitions or at different dates. ¹⁵

The age profile appears to have changed, or at least the public-facing offer has. In 2016, the anniversary article said members ranged from **age six to 54**, which implies adult participation and fits with the 2015 AGM's creation of a **swim4fitness** group for non-competitive or recovering swimmers. The current "Join us" page, however, is much more explicitly junior-development focused: it welcomes **children aged 5+** who can swim unaided and are working at about **Stage 5 of the Learn to Swim pathway**, while still naming "new junior and masters members welcome" in the page header. The most plausible reading is that BASC historically supported a broader age range, while its current main public recruitment message is aimed at junior swimmers. ¹⁶

Beyond age, the online demographic evidence is thin. No open-access source located during this research gave a year-by-year gender split, ward/postcode distribution, school mix, ethnicity breakdown, or socioeconomic profile. That absence is unsurprising: the club's privacy notice and public-site approach restrict member information, and modern safeguarding/data-protection norms reduce public availability of detailed membership demographics. ¹⁷

The governance model is easier to evidence. The club is constitution-based and committee-led. The 2015 AGM minutes show formal approval of the constitution and an elected officer structure including chair, secretary, treasurer, social secretary, health and safety, kit secretary, welfare officer and club captains. Current pages present the club as being run "**almost entirely by volunteers**", from coaching to officiating, and stress volunteer roles for families. The welfare page adds that coaches, teachers and volunteers are recruited under a safe-recruitment policy with DBS checks and safeguarding training. ¹⁸

Affiliation and accreditation have evolved over time. The club's welcome pack states affiliation to **East Region ASA** and **Hertfordshire ASA**. Current county and regional sources place Bushey ASC squarely within the Swim England Hertfordshire / Swim England East ecosystem. County annual reports show the club as **swim21/SwimMark accredited** in 2015, 2016 and 2021, but county records also note that Bushey ASC had **lost SwimMark accreditation** in January 2018, regained it by 2020/21, and by the end of **2024** was listed not under SwimMark but under **Club Affiliation**. That is analytically significant: it suggests governance compliance and affiliation continuity, but not a perfectly linear accreditation history. ¹⁹

League and competition affiliations are also visible, though unevenly documented across time. The current club site says BASC competes in **county swimming leagues and other local galas**. Newsletter evidence shows participation in the **Peanuts League** for younger swimmers in 2004–05, and a 2005 newsletter refers to Bushey swimmers taking part in a **Herts Masters** competition. More recent official materials show Bushey swimmers in county qualifiers, regional competition structures and open-water championship programmes. ²⁰

Funding, facilities and community role

Historically, the club appears to have relied mainly on a typical amateur-club funding mix: **member subscriptions/fees, volunteer labour, raffles and internal fundraising**, with only limited evidence online of major long-run corporate sponsorship. The strongest direct evidence comes from the welcome pack and AGM material: the club runs a **100 Club** to raise funds; raffles are held at club championships; and memberships/subscriptions are actively managed and occasionally increased. The 2015 AGM minutes also show that the club made a loss partly because of **increased pool time** and the

introduction of a paid coach, which indicates that pool hire and coaching were material cost pressures. ²¹

There is also evidence of external support linked to governance status. Hertfordshire ASA/Swim England Hertfordshire annual reports state that SwimMark/swim21 clubs were eligible for county support for officials' courses, CPD and coaching qualifications, sometimes up to set subsidy ceilings. That is not sponsorship in the commercial sense, but it is a real historical funding/support stream that benefited well-governed clubs such as Bushey when accredited. ²²

Evidence for **major sponsors** is weak. The clearest branded example I found was the club's **Specsavers Team of the Year Award**, which shows at least one named sponsor attached to an award/trophy. The 2004 newsletter also records **Bushey Grove Leisure Centre** providing swimming facilities free of charge for a Sports Relief-related club event, which is best described as important **in-kind support** rather than commercial sponsorship. I did **not** find open-access evidence of a long historic sequence of major external sponsors. ²³

The facilities story is central to the club's identity. The origin context is the **King George open-air pool** opened in 1925; the mid-century facility improvements there are well documented; and the pool's late-century decline and closure explain the club's later dispersed indoor geography. By 2004–05 BASC was demonstrably using **Bushey Grove Leisure Centre** and **John Owen Sports Centre**; by 2026 the official record showed Bushey Grove as the main base and additional training at **St Margaret's Sports Centre, Merchant Taylors School Sports Complex, St Helens School and Inspire: Luton Sports Village**. That mix suggests a club that has survived by becoming adaptable and multi-site. ³

The community role is well evidenced in the modern sources. The current join page frames BASC as a **"community-focused club with a strong family atmosphere"**, offering a supportive route for children who are ready to move from structured lessons into club training and competition. The welcome pack says club sessions **complement formal swimming lessons rather than replace them**, which suggests BASC's role is not beginner learn-to-swim in the municipal sense, but that crucial bridge between lessons and competitive/club swimming. The use of school pools also implies sustained school/facility partnerships even where formal school outreach programmes are not publicly documented. ²⁴

Charity/community fundraising appears episodic rather than institutionalised in the open record. The 2004 newsletter shows BASC joining **Sports Relief** fundraising activity. The 2016 anniversary article described trips, guest speakers, nutrition sessions, fun swims, raffles and awards evenings, which together paint the picture of a club with a meaningful social/community layer as well as a competitive one. ²⁵

Archival sources, source comparison and online visual material

The club's history is recoverable, but only partly from the open web. The strongest repositories for the next stage are **Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies**, which offers archive-catalogue access and historical newspapers; **Bushey Museum**, which holds local-history materials and a substantial run of journals; **Swim England Hertfordshire**, whose annual reports preserve affiliation/accreditation evidence; and the club's own AGM/newsletter/trophy pages. ²⁶

The table below compares the most useful source families. The "Reliability" column is my assessment based on provenance and how directly each source bears on the question.

Source	Type	Date range covered	Reliability	Access
Bushey ASC welcome pack	Club/official PDF	Modern, with retrospective founding claim	High for current structure, affiliation and membership snapshot; moderate for early-history claim	Club PDF ²⁷
BASC AGM minutes	Club primary documents	At least 2015–2016 visible online	High for governance, anniversary planning, funding pressures and named officers	2015 AGM minutes PDF ²⁸
Bushey ASC current website and centenary page	Official club website	Current	High for present public offer; moderate for historical interpretation because the centenary page is still a placeholder	Club site / centenary page ²⁹
Swim England Poolfinder	National governing-body platform	Current snapshot	High for present membership count, locations and club status	Poolfinder entry ³⁰
Swim England Hertfordshire annual reports and county papers	County governing-body records	2012–2025 visible online	High for affiliation/ accreditation changes and county ecosystem context	Annual reports/ minutes ³¹
Hertsmere / ParksHerts King George Recreation Ground history	Official local-authority / partner heritage page	1912–1990s facility history	High for pool opening, upgrades, decline and closure	Council/ Parks history ³²
Bushey Museum journals and archive pages	Local museum/ heritage source	1930s images recalled; journals 1988–2019 online	Moderate to high for local context, images and recollections; needs cross-checking for club-specific claims	Museum journals/ archive pages ³³
Local news anniversary feature	Local press/ magazine	2016	Moderate: useful and specific, but should be checked against primary club/council sources	My Local News / Calaméo copy ⁷

Source	Type	Date range covered	Reliability	Access
Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies	Official archive service	Historic records and papers	Very high potential, but much relevant material is offline or catalogue-based rather than fully digitised	HALS research pages ³⁴

A few online visual/documentary items are especially worth opening because they can anchor further archive requests:

Item	Why it matters	Link
King George Recreation Ground leaflet PDF	Official narrative of the pool's construction, growth, closure and demolition, with historical imagery	³⁵
BASC 2015 AGM minutes PDF	Strong primary document for the 90th anniversary, governance, funding and named officers/coaches	²⁸
"Bushey Swimming Pool. c. 1930"	Useful online historical image of the founding-era facility; provenance should be checked before publication use	³⁶
"Bushey open air swimming pool c. 1930's?"	Second historical image of the facility environment, again best used as a lead for provenance checking	³⁷

For **primary-document chasing**, the most promising exact search/request terms are:

- "Bushey Amateur Swimming Club"
- "Bushey Swimming Club"
- "Bushey ASC"
- "King George Recreation Ground swimming pool"
- "Bushey open-air swimming pool"
- "Bushey swimming gala"
- "Bushey Urban District Council swimming pool tenders"
- "Bushey Recreation Ground committee minutes 1924 1925 1926"
- "BASC AGM"
- "Wendy Cook", "Howard Willis", "Alan Brown", "Jack Jackson" in club minutes/newsletters
- "Bushey Swimming Bath" in photo captions and local press indexes. ³⁸

Gaps, uncertainties and recommended next steps

Several important facts remain uncertain. The biggest gap is the **exact founding event**: no open-access founding notice, inaugural meeting minute, first committee list or first ASA affiliation record surfaced during this research. The second major gap is **wartime club activity**, especially 1939–45. The third is a precise **relocation chronology** from the open-air pool era to the indoor multi-site era. The fourth is a robust long-run **membership series**. Finally, the 2016 claim about swimmers reaching the Commonwealth Games and Olympic trial level is plausible, but the relevant athletes are still **unidentified in the open record located here**. ³⁹

The best next verification steps are straightforward and practical. First, ask **Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies** for help locating **Bushey Urban District Council / parks / recreation committee**

minutes covering roughly **1924–1926**, plus any files on the pool opening, tenders and running arrangements. Secondly, use HALS historical newspapers access to search the **Watford Observer** and other local papers for 1925–1927 references to the pool opening, the first gala and the first club notices. Thirdly, contact the club via the centenary history address on the centenary page and ask whether there are surviving **minute books, trophy ledgers, old newsletters, programmes, annual reports, centenary planning notes or photo albums**. Fourthly, check **Bushey Museum** for photographs and caption files relating to the open-air pool and for any donor deposits mentioning BASC. ⁴⁰

If you want the missing facts nailed down with the least wasted effort, the exact records I would request are:

- **Bushey Urban District Council** minutes or committee papers on the pool opening and pool management, **1924–1926**.
- **Local newspaper issues, July 1925 to September 1926**, especially around the pool opening and the first full 1926 season.
- **BASC AGM packs/minutes/newsletters** from the earliest surviving decade, ideally pre-1970 if extant.
- **Trophy registers / engraving books / award ledgers**, because the online trophy pages already show surviving internal memory back into the **1960s and 1970s**.
- **Photograph accession files** at Bushey Museum for open-air pool and gala images.
- **County affiliation/accreditation files** at Swim England Hertfordshire or predecessor Hertfordshire ASA. ⁴¹

Short sources list

The principal sources used for this report were the **Bushey Amateur Swimming Club website, welcome pack, AGM minutes and trophy pages; Swim England Poolfinder; Swim England Hertfordshire annual reports and management-board papers; Hertsmere / ParksHerts King George Recreation Ground history; Bushey Museum journals and archive pages; Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies research and newspaper pages; and a 2016 local anniversary feature** reproduced online. ⁴²

¹ ⁶ ⁸ ¹⁹ ²¹ ²⁷ ⁴² <https://www.busheyasc.org/policies/BASC%20Welcome%20Pack.pdf>
<https://www.busheyasc.org/policies/BASC%20Welcome%20Pack.pdf>

² ³ ¹⁰ ¹⁴ ³² ³⁵ <https://www.hertsmere.gov.uk/asset-library/imported-assets/08-Parks-Leisure/Parks-Open-Spaces/Park-facilities/Bushey/king-george-recreation-ground-leaflet.pdf>
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⁴ ⁹ ¹⁵ ³⁰ <https://www.swimming.org/poolfinder/clubs/666/1003797/Bushey%2BAmateur%2BSwimming%2BClub/>
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⁵ ²⁶ ³⁴ ³⁸ ⁴⁰ <https://www.hertfordshire.gov.uk/services/libraries-and-archives/hertfordshire-archives-and-local-studies/hertfordshire-archives-and-local-studies.aspx>
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⁷ ¹⁶ ³⁹ <https://www.calameo.com/mylocalnews/books/0044332673d4a9ed8d646>
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